

books were provided by the government, they were often left unused, locked away due to a lack of teachers or interest. To address this, Utthan Sahayaks introduced the DEAR (Drop Everything And Read) period. Every first and third Saturday, students from Classes 1 to 8 issue books, and on the second and fourth Saturdays, book reviews and other reading activities are held. This approach has successfully nurtured a reading culture, especially among first-generation learners.

During the 2023-24 academic year alone, students borrowed an impressive 389,742 books. Presently, there are over 300 reading corners stocked with 150,000 age-appropriate books, fostering a daily reading habit in Utthan schools. Mothers attending their meetings have also started borrowing books, further bolstering this remarkable initiative.

One of the project's innovative strategies was tackling the lack of engagement often seen in parent-teacher meetings (PTMs) and the School Management Committee (SMC). Ensuring the project's sustainability required the active involvement of these stakeholders.

Utthan Sahayaks began organising Mothers' Meet on the fourth Saturday of every month. Initially, participation was minimal, with attendance in the single digits. To make these meetings more appealing, the Sahayaks introduced traditional games, which gradually attracted more mothers. As a result, attendance steadily increased, reaching 90 to 95%. In the last academic year alone, 2,574 gatherings were held, with over 51,000 mothers participating. Furthermore, more than 200 mothers now actively contribute to the SMC.

This multi-faceted approach extensively improved the quality of the schools involved. Several government schools that initially ranked in C or D grades in Gunotsav—a quality assessment initiative by the Government of Gujarat—have now reached A+, A, or B grades. Gunotsav focuses on improving learning outcomes at the elementary level, assessing schools in four key areas: teaching and learning outcomes, school management, co-scholastic activities, and resource utilization.

Moreover, the Adani Evening Education Centres within the Utthan initiative offer supplementary classes to high school students, boosting their performance in board exams. This intervention has successfully raised the board exam results of government high schools from 33.23% to 100%. In addition, the Adani Competitive Coaching Centres equip students with the necessary skills to excel in various scholarships and competitive exams, ensuring their academic and future success. Between 2018 and 2023, 448 students from marginalised communities gained admission or received scholarships through district and state government initiatives due to this intervention.

In addition to its core initiatives, Project Utthan has worked to make government school infrastructure more engaging by implementing BALA (Building as Learning Aid) paintings. These vibrant wall paintings serve as educational tools, allowing students to use them as learning resources. Another unique approach is the "IT on Wheels" programme, which brings basic computer literacy to Utthan schools through mobile vans equipped with 50 laptops and an IT instructor. Currently, five vans operate in Mundra, Hazira, Dahej, and Dhamra, benefiting over 5,000 students. Through this programme, students gain essential skills in MS Word, PowerPoint, and Excel over a three-year period.

This academic year, the project has also introduced a new intervention—Abacus, Mental Math, and Vedic Mathematics. This programme will run until 2027, during which over 10,000 students will become certified mental math champions, earn-

ing 10 certificates as they progress through each level.

What began as a project in 17 schools across 7 villages, serving 2,598 students, has now expanded to 316 government primary and high schools, impacting 51,298 students from over 150 villages across five states: Gujarat, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, and Odisha.

Through these initiatives, Project Utthan continues to reach the most marginalised and underserved students, supporting both state and central governments in achieving their educational goals.

